Kiran Desai scoffs at the word anticipation. "It was completely quiet," she says, laughing, of the 19-year wait for her new novel, *The Loneliness of Sonia and Sunny*. "Maybe some friends would have said, 'Are you ever going to finish?'. But no, I didn't feel anticipation knocking at my door."

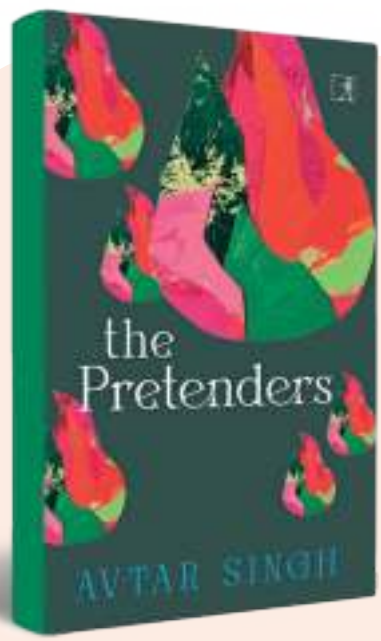
Desai is down-to-earth and disarming in a video call from her home in New York. It's her third novel and first since *The Inheritance of Loss*, which won the Man Booker Prize in 2006. "It was a wonderful thing," she says, of the win. "It really allowed me to think of myself as a writer and to give myself the time. This time taken perhaps came from that confidence that I now have the time to work."

Desai spent years writing and rewriting *Loneliness...*, excising large chunks and sieving out only the parts that had "sparks of life". Her mother Anita Desai, a three-time Booker Prize nominee and Desai's literary confidante, saw a 1,000-page draft ("still a big mess") once it was down from 5,000 pages, often providing encouragement and critique.

Loneliness..., shortlisted for the 2025 Booker Prize, is a lush, sprawling saga spanning generations and continents. It's anchored by the titular Sunny and Sonia, two young immigrants to the US; both aspiring writers, both grappling with split lives, family dynamics, class equations and racial politics. "I wanted to write about the loneliness of our globalised world and I had the idea of doing that through the lens of an unresolved love



At nearly 700 pages, ***Loneliness...*** **is an immersive read, richly plotted and populated,** with an eclectic, memorable cast of family, friends and frenemies



THE PRETENDERS
by Avtar Singh
SIMON & SCHUSTER INDIA
₹599; 320 pages

BOOKS ▼

Masks We Wear

IN *THE PRETENDERS*, **AVTAR SINGH** TURNS THE ISOLATION OF THE PANDEMIC INTO A MIRROR FOR HUMAN CONNECTION AND FRACTURE

In perhaps the most stunning first act I have read in a recent Indian novel, Avtar Singh's *The Pretenders* begins with Rahim, a Muslim man, carrying his dead Hindu friend Umakant's corpse around Delhi, looking for a crematorium and a Brahmin to conduct the last rites. Rahim's day takes a dark detour when he stops to catch his breath underneath a tree at a park—and is promptly yelled at, asked to leave immediately, and called a "sister-fucking purbiya" for good measure (in the derogatory context, 'purbiya' is directed at people from Bihar and eastern UP).

Is there anything more Delhi than rich folks cordoning off their land as though it were a war zone? *The Pretenders*, however, isn't a Delhi novel per se. In fact, in style and treatment it is far closer to the super-ambitious "connection novels" (to borrow a term from the writer-critic Keshava Guha) of the mid-2000s; think Hari Kunzru's *Transmission* or David Mitchell's